



NOUGHT TO KNOT

Women inmates at a probation home in Ranchi get a new life as the authorities endeavour to settle them in matrimony

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

Matches may be made in heaven but marriages are arranged on earth. Mainee, 23—a petite and shy looking inmate of Women Probation Home in Ranchi, Jharkhand—is all set to marry Sanjay Karmakar, 32, a Ranchi-based lawyer, whom she has met just once and fell in love with. That their union is brought about by the home officials and efforts are on to settle other inmates in matrimony in a similar fashion is the unique selling point of this couple's story.

It is an ordinary looking house with 61 extraordinary stories. Apart from those involved in petty crimes, the home also houses women who have been abandoned by their husbands, besides a dozen teenagers, some of whom were once involved with the Maoists. "Many of these girls are destitute and have nowhere to go," says Renu Sinha, superintendent of the probation home. This tiny oasis

houses some young, some adolescents and even newborns, like the one who was born last year to a woman who was raped and abandoned on the city streets.

This shelter for destitute women charged with petty crimes has been instrumental in arranging 13 other such marriages. The inmates are excited about two impending weddings within a short span of time. Twenty-four-year-old Angoori, too, will be following Mainee down the aisle. She will marry Bhootnath Toppo, a farmer in Ranchi. "I don't know who my parents are," says Angoori, who like many of the girls here, has never had any brush with good fortune so far.

The dates for the two marriages are yet to be finalised as the officials are carrying out the final checks on the two men, who have volunteered to marry the girls. Indeed, the government officials are doing everything that a family would to vet a prospective bridegroom for the girls before solemn-

▲ SAWITA AND WILLIAM BHENGRA

Married to a carpenter in 2003, Sawita is now a mother of two.

"I am happy with him. I have a television and my own house in Ranchi."

▼ MAMTA DEVI & JAGDISH MAHTO

Mamta, who left her parents' house in a fury, is now married to a lawyer.

"I have my own family but I wish to trace my parents now."



"We ensure the well-being of these girls even after marriage."

SUNIL BARNWAL, STATE INSPECTOR GENERAL OF PRISONS